

ARCH STUDIO X: ADVANCED STUDIO: THE LIBRARY

ARCH 546/420 SYLLABUS

SPRING 2025

Monday/Wednesday/Friday 2:00 to 6:00 pm

Instructor: Professor Donna Robertson robertson@iit.edu 312-543-5696
Prof. Martin Felsen felsen@iit.edu 312-617-4268
Office Hours: by appointment.
Studio Drive: [Y5 Studio Drive S2025 Robertson Felsen](#)

Regenstein Library (<https://www.lib.uchicago.edu/spaces/joseph-regenstein-library/>) opened in 1970 as the centralized, consolidated library for University of Chicago,. As one of the largest repositories of books in the world, it holds an indomitable position on campus as the heart of a major research university, and a magnet for all scholars. An iconic example of Brutalist architecture designed by Walter Netsch of SOM-Chicago, it responds to the Gothic architecture of the traditional campus, mitigating its bulk within the whole ensemble.

Over seven stories and 577,085 gross square feet, it houses acres of book shelving, student study spaces, faculty research offices, special collections, book curation, exhibition and administration spaces. It holds over 4.5 million print volumes focusing on subjects in the humanities and social sciences, as well as business, divinity, and area studies.

The Regenstein's Mansueto Library addition of 2011 expanded storage capacity for another 3.5 million volumes, utilizing an underground robotic book retrieval system topped by an oval, glass-domed reading room and book curation spaces. This has ensured that the whole university book collection remains for the moment on campus, a faculty-driven imperative.

However, growth continues as U. Chicago maintains its primacy as a research university. As well, modes of study and teaching call for innovation in the types of spaces and interactions that the library wishes to foster. Thus, the Regenstein is in the planning stage for another expansion, and a major re-working of its existing space. This studio will work closely with the Dean of Libraries, Torsten Reimer, and his staff to consider possibilities for all changes and additions. This will entail close study of existing operations, and speculation for future possibilities for new and re-ordered spaces.

Universities grew as sites of book-sponsorship, research and instruction: they assemble the world's knowledge for on-going investigation of the truth. "Let knowledge grow from more to more; and so be human life enriched" is U. Chicago's motto. This growth now necessitates the university considering off-site print journal storage, as digital practices allow for easier access to less-used materials. In general, the Regenstein continues to evolve to find new ways of enhancing the scholarly research and project of learning for its university, and world, community.

PROCESS

Students will work in teams of two (only.) Initial research involves visits to the library, to interview those involved in its planning and operations; we will work closely with Dean Reimer and his staff to consider possibilities for expansion and reorganization. Individual observation leading to innovative insights into improvements will be valued; learn the library in all its parts.

Student teams will present background on current university library developments. As well, we will study the background to the legacy of Walter Netsch's architecture, and why Regenstein holds such an iconic status in the architectural history of the second half of the 20th century.

Research (weeks 1-3): Lifestyles, Programs & Infrastructures

The initial discovery phase, built around trips to the library, will research unique possibilities for library operations and atmosphere. Build a catalog of programs that you can imagine might support these lifestyles. Add programs to the catalog that might be leveraged to create new possible lifestyles. This research will be done by each team, and the work will be collected into a studio book (InDesign file to be provided).

As well, we will try as much as possible to keep this a Paperless Studio, with the suggestion that all presentations and final product be digital. *Each student will be expected to compile all work from all phases at the end of the semester, to turn in to the instructor loaded onto the studio Drive. Preparation and organization of a project's work will factor into grading evaluation.*

RESEARCH PHASE: PROJECTS FOR CASE STUDY

Each student will research and present a case study of a contemporary library. Full documentation, especially for site planning purposes. One original graphic that summarizes the architect's intention. Subjects include:

1. Berlin Staatsbibliothek, Hans Scharoun, 1967, Germany
2. Wells Library, Walter Netsch/SOM, 1968, New York State, USA
3. Exeter Library, Louis Kahn, 1972, New Hampshire, USA
4. Bibliotheque National de France, Dominique Perrault, 1996, Paris, France
5. TU Delft Library, Mecanoo, 1998, The Netherlands
6. Sendai Mediatique, Toyo Ito, 2001, Japan
7. Alexandria Library, Snohetta, 2001, Egypt
8. Utrecht University Library, Wiel Arets, 2004, The Netherlands
9. Beijing National Library addition, KSP Jurgen Engel Architekten, 2008, China
10. Information, Communications & Media Centre, Herzog & Demeuron, 2004, BTU Cottbus, Germany
11. Rolex Learning Center, SANAA, 2010, Lausanne, Switzerland
12. Qatar National Library, OMA, 2017, Doha, Qatar
13. Oodi Central Library, ALA Architects, 2018, Helsinki, Finland
14. Beijing Sub-center Library, Snohetta, 2023, China

REQUIREMENTS

- | | |
|---------------------------|----------------------------|
| 1. Library case study | 5. Midterm Review |
| 2. Research analysis | 6. Final Presentation Plan |
| 3. Initial Concept Review | 7. Final Review |
| 4. Final Concept Review | |

READINGS

Readings will be assigned as the course progresses, and will be placed on reserve in the GRC library or on the studio Drive: [Y5 Studio Drive S2025 Robertson Felsen](#)

1. *The Meaning of the Library: A Cultural History*, Alice Crawford, ed. Chapters 10-12.
2. *Library: An Unquiet History*, Matthew Battles.
3. "Innovation on a Grand Scale: Revisiting Regenstein Library at 50", Daniel Meyer, <https://www.lib.uchicago.edu/about/news/innovation-grand-scale-revisiting-regenstein-library-50/>
4. "No Researcher is an Island", Torsten Reimer, <https://www.lib.uchicago.edu/about/news/no-researcher-is-an-island/>
5. "How Regenstein Library Ushered in a New Era of Scholarly Distinction", *YouTube*, Dean Boyer, <https://youtu.be/WKPenP86nfE?si=XI9ccFznGVKCP-TM>
6. "UChicago Library expands access to banned books . . .", *YouTube*, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DpHrJWPYOXs>
7. UChicago Photographic Archive for Regenstein Library: <https://photoarchive.lib.uchicago.edu/db.xqy?keywords=Regenstein+library>
8. "The Regenstein Library—Brutalist Architecture", drone footage, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=fD8Kklh5rOQ>
9. "A Radical Mind", interview with Walter Netsch, *SOM Journal* 1. <https://som.medium.com/a-radical-mind-the-genius-of-architect-walter-netsch-ba0315069e31>
10. "Why our future depends on libraries, reading and daydreaming," Neil Gaiman, *The Guardian*, 10.15.2013 <https://www.theguardian.com/books/2013/oct/15/neil-gaiman-future-libraries-reading-daydreaming>
11. *Libraries: A Design Manual*, Lushington, Rudolf, Wong, pp. 10-61
12. "Books in Space: Tradition and Transparency in the Bibliotheque de France", Antony Vidler, *Representations*, Spring 1993 (posted in Drive)
13. *Portrait d'un Projet*, Dominique Perrault on Bibliotheque Nationale de France.
14. "Koolhaas's Libraries", Shannon Mattern, *Wordspace*,
15. "Library as Infrastructure", Shannon Mattern.
16. "The History of the Library: Why Bigger Isn't Always Better", *Financial Times*, 10.04.2019
17. "Pushing Past Mies", Neil Flanagan, *The Architect's Newspaper*, 01.07.2020, re. Mies Library renovation, Washington DC <https://www.archpaper.com/2021/01/mecanoos-renovation-of-the-martin-luther-king-jr-memorial-library-works-through-the-nuances-of-the-miess-signature-style/>

GRADING

Grades for the course will be based on the participant's class preparation and participation in discussions, together with the required design development and final project. It is hoped that each student will bring to the course energy, enthusiasm for the combined studio effort and subject matter, and a curiosity that encourages original insights and speculative thinking. Good class attendance is the first indication of such an attitude; three late arrivals (after 2:30 pm) and/or missed classes will result in the lowering of the final grade by one full letter. Four missed classes without an excuse for documented medical reasons or personal crisis will mean that the instructor has the option to withdraw the student from the class.

Final grades will be based on the following allotments:

Case study and research presentations	15%
Preparation for, and participation in discussions/desk crits	15%
Design development	15%
Final Project	45%
Overall effort	10%

ACCOMMODATION

Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA) Policy Statement

Reasonable accommodations will be made for students with documented disabilities. In order to receive accommodations, students must go through the Center for Disability Resources office. The Center for Disability Resources (CDR) is located at Life Sciences Room 218, telephone 312.567.5744 or <https://www.iit.edu/cdr>.

Additional student resources to include:

Academic Resource Center (ARC): Hermann Hall for help with study or language skills. <http://iit.edu/arc/>
IIT Writing Center: One-to-one help with writing assignments. <https://www.iit.edu/cac/writing-guides/help-writing-assignments>

Student Health and Wellness Center: provides health care, advocacy, wellness resources
student.health@iit.edu

Therapy/Psychiatric Counseling: <https://www.iit.edu/shwc/appointments/counseling-appointments>
Code of Academic Honesty: <https://web.iit.edu/student-affairs/handbook/fine-print/code-academic-honesty> . Send ALL violations to academichonesty@iit.edu.

Patent and Copyright Policy https://webmaster.iit.edu/files/general-counsel/faculty-handbook/appendix_k.pdf

Also see <https://web.iit.edu/cac/student-resources/writing-guides/writing-process/plagiarism-and-avoiding-it>

Student Code of Conduct: https://webmaster.iit.edu/files/general-counsel/faculty-handbook/code_of_conduct.pdf

Student Handbook: <https://web.iit.edu/student-affairs/handbook/fine-print/code-academic-honesty>

Studio Culture: <https://arch.iit.edu/about/studio-culture>

COVID-19 Precautions and Guidelines

While not required, we encourage you to provide the following link to all on campus Covid related guidelines in your syllabus. <http://iit.edu/COVID-19>

ARCH 546_420_ARCH STUDIO S2025: ROBERTSON/FELSEN CALENDAR

Spring 2025 Schedule--TENTATIVE

01.08.2025

Week 1	Activity	Format	Location
1/13	Studio Lottery, Introduction		Crown Hall
1/15	Studio discussion and Case Study assignments	Seminar	UC2
1/17	Studio		
Week 2			
1/20	Martin Luther King Day, no classes		
1/22	Studio		
1/24	CASE STUDY PRESENTATION	REVIEW	UC2
Week 3			
1/27	FIELD TRIP REGENSTEIN LIBRARY	TOUR,, discussion	U. Chicago
1/29	Studio		
1/31	Studio		
Week 4			
2/3	Studio		
2/5	SITE AND PROGRAM RESEARCH PRESENTATION		UC2
2/7	Studio		
Week 5			
2/10	FIELD TRIP REGENSTEIN LIBRARY	Discussion w Dean Libs.	U. Chicago
2/12	Studio CONCEPT PRESENTATION		UC2
2/14	Studio		
Week 6			
2/17	Studio		
2/19	Studio		
2/21	Studio		
Week 7			
2/24	Studio		
2/26	DESIGN PROPOSAL REVIEW	REVIEW	UC2
2/28	Studio		
Week 8			
3/3	Studio		
3/5	Studio		
3/7	Studio		
Week 9			
3/10	Studio		
3/12	Studio		
3/14	MIDTERM REVIEW	REVIEW	UC2
Week 10			
3/17	SPRING BREAK		
3/19	SPRING BREAK		
3/21	SPRING BREAK		
Week 11			
3/24	Studio		
3/26	Studio		
3/28	Studio		
Week 12			
3/31	Studio		
4/2	Studio		
4/4	Studio		
Week 13			
4/7	Studio		
4/9	PRESENTATION PLAN REVIEW	Pin up	UC2
4/11	Studio		
Week 14			
4/14	Studio		
4/16	Studio		
4/18	Studio		
Week 15			
4/21	Studio		
4/23	Studio		
4/25	Studio		
Week 16			
4/28	Studio		
4/30	Studio		
5/2	FINAL REVIEW	REVIEW	UC2